

First troops

The first Marines to arrive in Vietnam stormed Red Beach Two in Da Nang on March 8, 1965, an entrance reminiscent of their amphibious landings in the Pacific during World War II. Rather than facing enemy troops, however, the “devil dogs” of the Ninth Marine Expeditionary Brigade were met by TV crews and welcome banners held by grateful South Vietnamese.

It was not long before they were engaged in counterinsurgency activities and open combat against Viet Cong guerrillas and NVA regulars. Their first major offensive, involving some 5,500 Marines, was Operation Starlite in August 1965, a mission to interdict and destroy Viet Cong forces massed around Chu Lai air base south of Da Nang.

By the end of 1965, the initial force of Marines had been augmented by units under the aegis of the III Marine Amphibious Force. Partnering with ARVN troops, the units protected rural hamlets along the DMZ. Later in the war, General Westmoreland sent these combined action platoons on search-and-destroy missions in the countryside. Typically, they were equipped with M-16 rifles, M60 machine guns, Ka-Bar combat knives, grenades, and machetes for hacking through the jungle.

“They are called the Viet Cong, but **you are Marines.** You are better trained. I expect all of you to **come home.**”

A COLONEL IN THE FOURTH MARINE REGIMENT TO HIS MEN, AUGUST 1965

Center stage

The Marines faced their biggest challenge in 1967 and 1968, when communist forces attacked Marine bases along the DMZ prior to the Tet Offensive. They repelled a fierce attack on Con Thien, endured a brutal 77-day siege at Khe Sanh, and ousted NVA and Viet Cong troops from Hue in bloody house-to-house fighting.

By the summer of 1969, Marine units began to withdraw from the war zone, though they formed part of the invasion of Cambodia in 1970. Most of the last ground units departed from Vietnam on June 25, 1971, leaving a small detachment to guard the US Embassy.

Twenty-six Marines were among the POWs handed over by North Vietnam after the 1973 peace treaty was signed. The Marines distinguished themselves again during the evacuations of the US embassies in Saigon and Phnom Penh (Cambodia), in April 1975, and in the rescue of the USS *Mayaguez* from the Khmer Rouge.